Deepti Sharma | 28 |

Innings: 7; Runs: 215; Average: 30.71
Wickets: 22; Strike Rate: 22.18; Economy: 5.52

India has Deepti's family to thank for backing her when neighbours in Agra questioned her choice of cricket as a career. Their faith paid off spectacularly, as she was named Player of the Tournament. In the opener against Sri Lanka, she rescued India with a composed 53 and, in the final, her five-wicket haul—highlighted by the dismissal of Annerie Dercksen just as South Africa were settling in—sealed the title. A complete all-rounder, Deepti brings balance to every department: sharp throws from the deep, dependable middle-order runs, and spin that can unnerve any batter.



AP

GROWING KITTY

- When the women's team returned after their first WC final in 2005, each player was paid Rs 8,000 in total—Rs 1,000 per match
- On reaching the 2017 finals, each player was given Rs 50 lakh for the feat
- It's a different ballgame now. For winning its first ICC Women's Cricket World Cup, Team India raked in prize money of $4.48 million (approx. Rs 40 crore); the BCCI also announced a handsome prize of Rs 51 crore

MATCH FEES

In October 2022, the BCCI implemented its pay equity policy, ensuring that both men and women in blue drew similar match earnings in international cricket

TESTS	ODIs	T20Is
Rs 15 lakh	Rs 6 lakh	Rs 3 lakh

ANNUAL PLAYER RETAINERSHIP

Sizeable discrepancy still exists in players' contracts, but then, women cricketers didn't even have contracts until 2015

TIER A **Rs 50 lakh:** Harmanpreet Kaur, Smriti Mandhana, Deepti Sharma

TIER B **Rs 30 lakh:** Renuka Thakur, Jemimah Rodrigues, Richa Ghosh, Shafali Verma

TIER C **Rs 10 lakh:** Yashika Bhatia, Rasha Yadav, Shreyanka Patil, Arundhati Reddy, Titas Sadhu, Amanjot Kaur, Uma Chetry, Sneh Rana, Pooja Vastrakar

the Indian women's team played no international cricket in 1978-83 and then again in 1987-91, the latter of which also meant missing the 1988 Women's Cricket World Cup in Australia. Indian women cricket's greatest bowler Jhulan Goswami says the same—there was uncertainty as to when the women's team would play. "Sometimes we'd play one series internationally in the whole year," she recalls. "It was very disappointing to see players who lost out on playing at the peak of their careers," says Shubhangi Kulkarni, former India captain and currently a member of the IPL Governing Council, the first woman in the position. The team made do with playing on matting and cement wickets, and muddy outfields. "There was no question of diving and stopping," adds Shubhangi. Jhulan cites how lack of professionalism hurt their prospects. Financial constraints meant procuring quality cricketing gear was a task.

TURNING OF THE TIDE

All it takes is just one win. For India, it came when the Mithali Raj-led team reached the finals of the 2017 World Cup, a televised tournament. It gave Indian women cricketers hope that they could perhaps conquer the last mile and fostered a sense of self-belief, which stood the team in